

DSAT Practice — Overall Structure

25 Solutions with Reasoning, Trap Alerts & Insights

Q1. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The text follows a clear three-part structure: (1) introduces architect Mireya Solano, (2) describes her early focus on passive cooling, and (3) notes her expansion into urban planning. This maps directly to choice A.

WHY WRONG: A) Only one architect is discussed, not two. | **B)** No problem/solution comparison is presented; the text profiles a person. | **D)** No scientific concept is defined or argued for wider application.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B may tempt students who see 'sustainable housing' and 'arid climates' as a problem, but the text describes a career trajectory, not a problem-solution argument.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Look for the text's organizing logic: person → early work → later expansion = biographical arc, not argumentative structure.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Count the logical 'beats': introduce → describe early work → note broadening = three-beat career profile.*

Q2. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The text opens with an earlier assumption (deep-sea corals grow negligibly slowly), then introduces Varga's study that challenges it (certain species grow up to 15 mm/year), then notes the broader implication (corals may play a larger role). This matches B exactly.

WHY WRONG: C) No methodology is critiqued or alternative proposed. | **D)** Only one type of coral is discussed in depth.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *A is tempting because the text mentions two viewpoints, but the earlier assumption is presented only to be overturned, not defended.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *'However' and 'this finding suggests' are structural signals: old view → new evidence → implication.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Spot the pivot word 'However'—it signals a challenge to an earlier position.*

Q3. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The text first identifies the Aymara's distinctive time concept (cultural practice), then contrasts it with the more common past-behind/future-ahead convention, and finally describes gestural evidence collected by linguist Rafael Nunez. This three-part flow matches A.

WHY WRONG: A) No hypothesis is proposed or limited; the text describes observed behavior. | **C)** The researcher is not introduced as the focus, and no career summary or reception is discussed. | **D)** No objections to a theory are described.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *C may attract students who notice the researcher's name, but the text's focus is the cultural phenomenon, not the researcher's career.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Ask: What is the text primarily about? The Aymara concept of time, not Nunez's biography.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Structure = unique practice → contrast with norm → supporting evidence.*

Q4. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: Ferreira is introduced as a classical cellist (musician introduction), praised for emotional depth (initial reputation), then described as releasing a genre-blending album that divided opinion (departure + mixed reception). Choice A captures all three beats.

WHY WRONG: **A)** The text does not cover an entire career, only two phases, and does not evaluate lasting influence. | **B)** The text does not compare two genres in the abstract; it describes one musician's work. | **C)** No controversy is resolved; the mixed reaction is left standing.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts with 'entire career,' but the text covers only early acclaim and one album, not a full chronology.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Notice the word 'however'—it signals a shift from reputation to departure.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Introduce musician → established reputation → surprising shift + reactions = A.*

Q5. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The text describes bioluminescent flashing (behavior), explains it attracts mates and varies by species (purpose + variation), then provides a statistic about 40+ cataloged patterns (illustrating the extent of variation).

WHY WRONG: **A)** No reclassification is proposed. | **B)** No experiment is conducted; the text reports cataloging, not hypothesis testing. | **D)** No technical term is defined or deemed outdated.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B is tempting because 'researchers' are mentioned, but cataloging patterns is observational, not experimental hypothesis testing.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *The final sentence gives a quantitative detail ('over forty') that illustrates the scope of variation described earlier.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Behavior → purpose/variation → illustrative detail = A.*

Q6. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The text describes Chandran's survey methodology (3,000 remote workers, twelve countries), presents the key finding (weekly virtual events → higher cohesion), and then states her conclusion (informal digital interactions offset isolation).

WHY WRONG: **A)** The text does not argue that remote work is harmful or propose a policy. | **C)** No comparison of two methodologies occurs. | **D)** No sociological theory is introduced or contradicted.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B may tempt students who associate remote work with isolation, but the text reports a finding rather than arguing for a policy change.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Methodology → finding → conclusion is a classic research-summary structure on the DSAT.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Survey → result → takeaway = A.*

Q7. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The text describes Pueblo ceramic traditions (artistic tradition), presents Kinley's argument that motifs marked clan identity (scholar's interpretation of social function), and then cites the pattern of identical motifs in residential clusters (evidence supporting that interpretation).

WHY WRONG: B) Only one civilization is discussed. | **C)** No decline or revival is mentioned. | **D)** No dating dispute is presented.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D may attract students who see 'archaeologist' and 'excavated sites,' but the text uses excavation evidence to support an interpretation, not to dispute a date.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Tradition → interpretation → supporting evidence is a common DSAT structure for humanities passages.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Art → scholar's claim → evidence = A.*

Q8. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The text introduces wind power (energy source), explains how turbines convert kinetic energy (how it works), and then cites Denmark as an example of wind power serving as a primary energy source (real-world example demonstrating viability).

WHY WRONG: A) No argument against a policy is made; the text is informational. | **C)** No limitation or engineering solution is described. | **D)** Only one energy source is discussed.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts if you read 'renewable energy' and assume an advocacy structure, but the text is expository, not argumentative.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Introduction → mechanism → example = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *What is it? → How does it work? → Real example = A.*

Q9. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The text presents a scholarly disagreement (literal vs. allegorical reading), summarizes each side's evidence (vivid descriptions vs. closing passages), and then introduces Voss's synthesizing position (the poem's power comes from the tension between both). This matches A.

WHY WRONG: A) No artistic movement is identified or evaluated for significance. | **B)** No biographical details about an author are given (the poem is anonymous). | **D)** No mystery is solved; Voss proposes coexistence, not a single answer.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts because the debate may feel like a 'mystery,' but Voss doesn't eliminate alternatives—she embraces both.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Debate → evidence on each side → synthesis = classic 'third way' structure.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Two sides + 'need not be mutually exclusive' = synthesis (A).*

Q10. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The text defines GDP (widely used metric), notes critics' objections about what GDP misses (limitations), and then describes alternative indices like the IDI and HDI (efforts to address those limitations). Choice A captures this progression.

WHY WRONG: A) Only one primary metric (GDP) is evaluated; the alternatives are presented as complements, not competitors to be evaluated against each other. | **B)** No replacement theory is proposed or tested against data. | **C)** The text does not trace GDP's historical development or changing use.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *C is tempting because GDP has a history, but the text doesn't trace that history; it simply defines the metric and moves to criticism.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Define → criticize → alternative = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Metric → its limitations → new approaches = A.*

Q11. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The text introduces fruit flies (research organism), explains their quick reproduction and genetic similarity to humans (why useful), and then describes how CRISPR has made them even more valuable (new technology enhancing usefulness).

WHY WRONG: A) No ethical concerns are raised. | **C)** No organism has 'fallen out of favor'; only fruit flies are discussed. | **D)** No biological concept is defined or argued to be misunderstood.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B may tempt students who associate CRISPR with ethical debates, but the text discusses utility, not ethics.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Organism → reasons for usefulness → technology amplifying usefulness = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Useful animal → why useful → new tech makes it more useful = A.*

Q12. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: Nussbaum's claim (literature cultivates moral imagination) is presented, then illustrated (novel about a refugee's journey deepening empathy), and then qualified (literature alone is insufficient; without reflection it can reinforce biases). This maps to A.

WHY WRONG: A) No debate is summarized; only Nussbaum's view is presented. | **B)** No educational practice is criticized or alternative proposed. | **D)** Only one philosopher is discussed.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *C tempts because Nussbaum is a well-known philosopher, but the text presents only her view, not a debate.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Claim → illustration → qualification = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Philosopher says X → example → 'however' caveat = A.*

Q13. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The text identifies urban heat islands (phenomenon), explains impervious surfaces as the cause (primary cause), mentions tree canopy and reflective roofing as solutions (potential solutions), and notes wealthier areas receive more investment (inequity in application).

WHY WRONG: B) No natural disaster or legislation is discussed. | **C)** No two cities are compared. | **D)** The text does not dispute the significance of urban heat islands.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because 'public health risks' sounds like a crisis narrative, but the text is analytical, not advocacy-oriented.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Phenomenon → cause → solutions → equity gap = four-beat structure matching A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *What → why → fix → but uneven = A.*

Q14. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The underlined portion shows a contrast: little commercial airplay BUT wide circulation among jazz musicians. This sets up the text's concluding point that Kovalenko influenced a generation of avant-garde composers despite lacking mainstream success. Choice A captures this contrast-as-setup function.

WHY WRONG: A) No flaw in technique is identified. | **B)** The underlined portion discusses reception, not biographical motivation. | **D)** No personal anecdote is offered; the portion discusses professional reception.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because 'emigrated from Kyiv' appears earlier, but the underlined portion itself is about reception, not biography.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Function questions ask what role the underlined part plays in the text's argument, not what it says in isolation.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Contrast (little airplay vs. musician circulation) sets up later point about lasting influence = A.*

Q15. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The underlined portion states that honeybees are widely regarded as the most important insect pollinators. The rest of the text introduces Reyes's meta-analysis, which found that wild bees collectively pollinate more crop varieties. So the underlined portion establishes a widely held view that the study challenges. This matches A.

WHY WRONG: A) No limitation of the study is identified in the underlined portion. | **B)** The meta-analysis's conclusion is stated later, not in the underlined portion. | **C)** No definition is provided.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because the underlined statement sounds factual, but its function in the text is to set up the contrast with the study's findings.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *When the underlined portion is followed by 'However,' it usually establishes a view that will be challenged.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *'Widely regarded' + 'However' after = sets up challenge = A.*

Q16. Correct Answer: C

REASONING: The text describes a discovery during restoration (hidden landscape), presents a material detail from chemical analysis (expensive ultramarine blue), and then explains the historical implication (wealthier patron than previously believed). Choice A mirrors this three-beat structure.

WHY WRONG: A) The artist is not identified, and aesthetic significance is not assessed. | **B)** No two techniques are compared. | **D)** Authenticity is not disputed; provenance is reconsidered.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts because 'provenance' can feel like an authenticity question, but the text reconsiders who commissioned the work, not whether it is genuine.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Discovery → analysis detail → historical implication = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Found something → analyzed it → changed the historical story = A.*

Q17. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The underlined portion notes that mangrove loss acceleration 'coincided with' rapid industrialization—a temporal relationship. The text then adds that Nakamura 'cautions' that correlation is not causation and mentions other contributing factors. So the underlined portion identifies a temporal relationship that is later qualified. This matches A.

WHY WRONG: B) The underlined portion is not the primary conclusion; it's an intermediate observation. | **C)** The underlined portion does not introduce a counterargument; it reports the researcher's own observation. | **D)** No key term is defined.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because the temporal relationship sounds like a main finding, but Nakamura's conclusion is more nuanced, and the underlined portion is qualified afterward.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *'Coincided with' = temporal relationship. 'However' + 'other factors' = qualification.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Coincidence noted → then qualified = A.*

Q18. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The text introduces Osman's finding about overestimating sensationalized risks (finding about cognitive bias), names it 'salience bias' (names and defines the bias), and then notes its citation by public health officials advocating for fall-prevention funding (practical application). Choice A captures all three beats.

WHY WRONG: A) No methodology is criticized. | **B)** No two competing theories are presented or tested. | **C)** No public health crisis is described; the text discusses a cognitive pattern.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *C tempts because 'public health officials' are mentioned, but the text focuses on the cognitive bias research, not on a crisis.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Finding → name/definition → real-world use = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Bias found → named → applied in policy = A.*

Q19. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: Arai challenges the one-directional model (Western artists influenced by Japanese prints), provides evidence of reciprocal influence (Japanese printmakers adopting Impressionist techniques), and then articulates the broader implication (complicating the narrative of Western innovation). Choice A captures this challenge-evidence-implication structure.

WHY WRONG: B) No single artist is credited with inventing a technique. | **C)** Only one critic (Arai) is discussed; no comparison of critics occurs. | **D)** The text does not call for institutional recognition.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because specific techniques are mentioned, but the text's point is about the direction of influence, not the invention of a technique.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Challenge to conventional view → evidence of reciprocity → broader implication = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *One-way model challenged → two-way evidence → implication = A.*

Q20. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The underlined portion ('an assumption that may not hold in ecosystems where apex predators have been removed only recently or where biodiversity is already low') specifies conditions that limit the resilience described earlier. This matches A.

WHY WRONG: A) No specific compensatory mechanism is exemplified in the underlined portion. | **B)** The central finding is that compensatory mechanisms buffer ecosystems; the underlined portion limits that finding. | **C)** The research question is about trophic cascades, not about conditions of removal.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because the underlined portion relates to the study's findings, but it does not restate them; it restricts their applicability.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *'May not hold' = limitation/condition, not restatement.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *'May not hold in...' = specifying when resilience doesn't apply = A.*

Q21. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: The text introduces Okonkwo's model (neuroscientist's model of aesthetic chills), explains the prediction-error-to-dopamine mechanism (mechanism the model proposes), and then presents critics noting that chills occur during predictable passages too (criticism suggesting the model is incomplete). Choice A captures this progression.

WHY WRONG: A) No medical condition or treatment is discussed. | **C)** No two experiments are compared. | **D)** No philosophical tradition is traced.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts because 'aesthetic experience' may sound philosophical, but the text is grounded in neuroscience, not philosophy.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Model → mechanism → criticism = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Scientist proposes X → explains how → critics say 'but also Y' = A.*

Q22. Correct Answer: B

REASONING: Marin observes that turnout correlates with civic association density, not race competitiveness (observation challenging conventional model), proposes 'mobilization networks' as an explanation (proposed explanation), and then acknowledges her cross-sectional data can't establish causation (methodological limitation qualifying the explanation). Choice A matches.

WHY WRONG: A) No decline in participation is described as the central phenomenon. | **C)** No commonality is argued to be coincidental; Marin posits a causal mechanism. | **D)** No policy initiative is introduced or evaluated.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because 'voter turnout' may evoke decline narratives, but the text is about what predicts turnout, not about turnout declining.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Observation vs. convention → explanation → limitation = A.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Finding contradicts standard model → proposed mechanism → caveat = A.*

Q23. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The underlined portion—"without making explicit the evaluative framework on which such judgments depend"—describes the problematic practice Asare identifies: critics present judgments as self-evident without revealing their underlying criteria. This omission is exactly what motivates his call for greater transparency. Choice A captures this function.

WHY WRONG: B) The solution (articulating criteria openly) is described in the sentence after the underlined portion, not within it. | **C)** No specific review is cited. | **D)** No limitation of Asare's proposal is conceded in the underlined portion.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *B tempts because 'methodological transparency' sounds like a solution, but the underlined portion describes the current problematic practice, not the proposed fix.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *The underlined portion identifies what is wrong (hidden frameworks); the sentence after it proposes how to fix it (articulate criteria openly).*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *Describes the problem → the rest proposes the fix = A.*

Q24. Correct Answer: A

REASONING: The text describes Vasquez's reinterpretation of trackways (reinterpretation of fossil evidence), explains photogrammetric modeling showed features more consistent with a giant bird (analytical basis), states this would be the earliest evidence of avian gigantism (potential significance), and notes that skeletal remains are needed for corroboration (gap in supporting evidence). Choice A captures all four beats.

WHY WRONG: B) The previous classification is challenged, not defended. | **C)** No disciplinary standard is proposed. | **D)** No genetic evidence is cited; the controversy is not resolved.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *D tempts because fossils and classification are involved, but the text explicitly says corroboration 'awaits'—the controversy is not resolved.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *Reinterpretation → analytical basis → significance → evidence gap = four-beat structure.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *New reading of old evidence → method → importance → but needs more proof = A.*

Q25. Correct Answer: D

REASONING: The underlined portion ('To be sure, algorithmic curation does expose listeners to artists they might never have encountered otherwise') concedes a positive aspect of the practice Fuentes has been criticizing. The sentence immediately after begins with 'Yet Fuentes maintains that this benefit is outweighed,' reasserting the negative overall assessment. This concession-then-reassertion pattern matches A.

WHY WRONG: **A)** The underlined portion is a concession, not a restatement of the conclusion. | **B)** The central argument (algorithms homogenize music) was introduced earlier, not in the underlined portion. | **C)** The underlined portion describes a benefit, not a harm.

■ **TRAP ALERT:** *C tempts because it mentions algorithms, but the underlined portion frames algorithmic curation as a benefit, not a harm.*

■ **KEY INSIGHT:** *'To be sure' is a classic concession signal on the DSAT. It acknowledges the other side before the main argument resumes.*

■ **FAST METHOD:** *'To be sure... Yet' = concede then reassert = A.*

TOPIC SUMMARY

TOP 3 MISTAKES — Overall Structure:

1. Confusing a biographical arc (introduce → early work → expansion) with a problem-solution structure.
2. Selecting an option that describes only part of the text's structure while ignoring a key structural beat.
3. Misreading a concession ('To be sure...') as the text's main argument rather than as a qualification.

TOP 3 RULES:

1. Count the structural 'beats'—introduction, development, conclusion—and match them to the answer choice that mirrors all beats.
2. For function-of-underlined-portion questions, ask what role the portion plays in the argument, not what it literally says.
3. Watch for pivot words ('However,' 'But,' 'To be sure... Yet') that signal structural shifts.

EXPECTED FREQUENCY: 2–3 questions per module. Structure/function questions appear in both easy and hard modules and are among the most common RW question types.